



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "does free will explain all evil?" in white, lowercase, sans-serif font.

does free
will explain
all evil?

One kind of example is what is sometimes called 'natural evil.' These are evils which do not seem to be caused by free will. Examples include the consequences of natural disasters like hurricanes and tsunamis, and the often terrible effects of disease.

However, the tsunami does not seem to have been the
result of anyone's free choices.

Suppose that you think that all of these assumptions are true. That does not mean that we have a satisfactory treatment of the existence of evil from a theist perspective.

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good

the ability
to harm others
is a great good

That is because even if we might have an explanation of why there is some evil in the world, we do not yet have an explanation of why we find in the world the particular kinds of evils we do.

Let's take a particular example: the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami, which is estimated to have killed about 228,000 people. The following seems very plausible:

So, for all we have said so far, the following seems

plausible:

There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the evil.

But we have so far been assuming this:

A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.

And this is enough to put together an argument.

The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami is an evil.



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A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "does free will explain all evil?" in white, bold, sans-serif font.

**does free
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all evil?**

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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